SOUTH AFRICA · CULTURAL INTELLIGENCE

The Cultural Brief *(SA)*

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Curated and contextualised South African arts and cultural activity — with editorial judgment, never algorithms.

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> *"The child is not dead / not at Langa nor at Nyanga / nor at Orlando nor at Sharpeville / nor at the police station at Philippi / where he lies with a bullet through his brain."*
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> — INGRID JONKER, *DIE KIND* ("THE CHILD"), 1963. TRANSLATED BY JACK COPE AND WILLIAM PLOMER.

Five days after Human Rights Day, the Klein Karoo Nasionale Kunstefees opens in Oudtshoorn. The timing is not incidental — it rarely is in a country where the cultural calendar carries more weight than it advertises.

The KKNK is South Africa's largest Afrikaans-medium arts festival: three decades of theatre, music, cabaret, visual art, and literary programming concentrated into eight days in a small Karoo town that briefly, improbably, becomes the cultural centre of a language spoken by more than six million people. To attend is to experience something that does not map onto South Africa's more easily characterised cultural landscapes. It is not Grahamstown's edgy, grant-funded experimentalism. It is not the Cape Town International Jazz Festival's urbane cosmopolitanism. It is specifically, stubbornly, Afrikaans — and in 2026, that specificity is more contested and more interesting than it has ever been.

The Jonker lines above are not ornament. Ingrid Jonker wrote "Die Kind" in 1960, about a real child shot in a Nyanga township as police dispersed a crowd. The poem was so exact about what it named that Mandela read it aloud in the National Assembly in May 1994 — in the original Afrikaans — as the opening act of the new democratic parliament. The choice was a statement: the language did not belong only to the people who had weaponised it. The new South Africa was claiming it whole.

That claim — Afrikaans as a language of multiple inheritances — is what the KKNK has been slowly, and unevenly, trying to honour since 1995. Whether it has succeeded is the question this week's long essay examines. The short answer: partially, with important exceptions, and in ways the festival's founding mythology did not anticipate.

This week also marks the close of the CDI's Making It! conference in Kramerville. That conversation — serious, practical, under-covered — contains some of the most honest thinking currently available

about what it means to sustain a creative economy under structural pressure.

The KKNK opens Saturday in the Klein Karoo — thirty-one years old, contested in the ways all living things are contested. Its programme contains Afrikaans that the founders would not have programmed, spoken by people the apartheid state had designated inferior. That expansion is real and incomplete in equal measure. The gap between those two facts is where the only interesting cultural work in Afrikaans is currently being done.

CURATED DISPATCHES

Klein Karoo Nasionale Kunstefees

OUDTSHOORN · 28 MARCH – 4 APRIL

The KKNK opens Saturday and runs through 4 April, drawing more than 60,000 attendees to a town of roughly 70,000. Over a hundred productions are programmed across theatre, music, visual art, comedy, and literary events. There is nowhere else in the South African calendar where you can see eight consecutive days of predominantly new South African theatrical work, at this density, in a non-metropolitan setting.

The literary programme — consistently the least attended and most intellectually serious part of the KKNK — includes sessions on the state of Afrikaans publishing and the particular pressures on Cape Afrikaans writing. The studio productions, where the festival's more formally ambitious work typically appears, are worth prioritising over the main-stage programme for anyone whose interest is in what the language is currently capable of rather than what it has always been comfortable with.

KKNK, Oudtshoorn. 28 March – 4 April. kknk.co.za.

Making It! 2026 — A Closing Note

KRAMERVILLE DESIGN DISTRICT, JOHANNESBURG · CONCLUDED 25 MARCH

The CDI's Making It! conference closed Tuesday after two days in Kramerville. The CDI began in 2001 with 63 makers; twenty-five years later it works with more than 8,300 creative enterprises across all nine provinces. That figure is not a growth metric. It is evidence that a specific approach — patient, relational, focused on building enterprise capacity rather than chasing export markets — produces durable results where more ambitious programmes have not. The conference recordings, when published, will constitute some of the more useful documentation of South African creative sector development produced this year.

Àṣẹ — Oliewenhuis Art Museum, Bloemfontein

THROUGH 16 JUNE 2026

The Oliewenhuis exhibition opened last Thursday and runs through 16 June. Its conceptual anchor is the Yoruba concept of *àṣẹ* — the vital force, the capacity to bring intention into reality. The curatorial decision to organise the exhibition around this concept rather than the more familiar Western frameworks for thinking about creative agency is a statement about which intellectual traditions are worth drawing on when South Africa examines its own artistic life.

Oliewenhuis Art Museum, Bloemfontein. Through 16 June 2026. Free entry first Sunday of each month.

The National Arts Council and the Governance Question That Has Not Gone Away

ARTS POLICY

The Goliath case has been resolved in the courts and is unresolved in every other sense that matters. The Venice pavilion will be empty. The section 16 arguments were presented and not engaged with. The absence of a response from the department — either a substantive engagement with the constitutional questions raised, or a credible account of what governance changes are being considered — is itself a form of response. The Bill of Rights is thirty years old. The institutions designed to give it operational meaning in the cultural domain are in a measurably weaker position than they were a decade ago. That deterioration did not happen through any single event. It happened through accumulation.

LONG ESSAY

The Festival and the Language: What the KKNK Owes the Afrikaans It Was Built On

In 1976, the South African government introduced Afrikaans as a compulsory medium of instruction in Black township schools. The policy was not introduced because the government believed Afrikaans was a valuable heritage language that Black children would benefit from learning. It was introduced because the bureaucrats responsible for Bantu education had decided that administrative efficiency required linguistic uniformity. The children of Soweto responded by walking out of their classrooms. The police responded by shooting them. June 16 is now Youth Day. The uprising it marks — which cost an estimated 176 lives in its first weeks by conservative count — was triggered in significant part by a language policy. That language was Afrikaans. It is a fact the language carries, and that any serious engagement with Afrikaans cultural life in South Africa is obliged to carry with it.

The KKNK was founded in Oudtshoorn in 1995 — one year into democratic South Africa — as a celebration of Afrikaans arts and culture. Its founding logic was, in the context of that moment, comprehensible: a language community that had for decades exercised cultural power through state institutions now needed to build the non-state infrastructure for its own cultural life. In the case of Afrikaans, the founding of the KKNK carried an implicit claim — that the language could be separated from the political project that had weaponised it.

Thirty-one years on, the question that claim generates has not been resolved. It has, however, been made more complex, more honest, and — in the best moments of the festival's recent programming — more interesting.

The foundational problem is demographic. Afrikaans is spoken as a home language by approximately six million South Africans. Of those six million, fewer than half are white Afrikaners. The majority are people the apartheid state classified as Coloured — communities descended from the Cape's enslaved people, from Khoi and San communities, from Malay and other Asian migrants brought to the Cape under Dutch and British colonial rule. The Afrikaans that these communities speak is not the Afrikaans of the language's nationalist historiography. It is an older inheritance — a language whose roots run through the Cape's slave quarters and fishing villages and mission schools rather than through the trekker republics of the interior.

The difference matters, and it has a literature. The Afrikaans that Adam Small wrote in — his poetry, his plays, his essays — was saturated with Cape Malay idiom, with the rhythms of working-class Cape speech, with a political fury at the apartheid state written in the language that state had appropriated. His 1962 play *Kanna hy kô hystoe* is among the most important works of twentieth-century South African theatre — not Afrikaans theatre: South African theatre — and it remains virtually unknown outside the Afrikaans-speaking world. Small died in 2016, having spent decades making work the KKNK was slow to programme and slower to centre. His absence from the founding mythology of the festival is not an oversight. It is a structural choice whose consequences continue.

There is also a textual tradition that the festival's cultural nationalism has systematically obscured. The Afrikaans Ajami tradition — Afrikaans written in Arabic script by Cape Muslim communities from the eighteenth century onward — predates the standardisation of Afrikaans in Roman script by at least a century. This body of work represents an Afrikaans literary culture that was never, in any meaningful sense, Afrikaner. That its existence is not widely known is the result of a historiography that decided, in the late nineteenth century, which communities were permitted to own the language.

Against this background, what the KKNK's founding mythology required was a strategic simplification: Afrikaans as the inheritance of one community, carrying forward one cultural tradition, making one kind of claim. That simplification was not malicious; it was the condition under which a festival could be built quickly, with a coherent identity and a reliable audience. The problem is that strategic simplifications, once institutionalised, develop constituencies. The constituencies resist revision.

The revision has nevertheless proceeded. The KKNK has, particularly in the last decade, made programming choices that reflect the full demographic of Afrikaans speakers with greater consistency. Productions in Cape Afrikaans vernacular, work by artists whose relationship to the language runs through the Cape Malay and Coloured communities, commissions that engage explicitly with the language's contested histories — all of these have increased in frequency and, in recent years, in prominence. This is not negligible progress. Institutional cultures change slowly and against the resistance of established constituencies.

Whether this constitutes structural transformation or expanded programming quota is the live argument, and it is not merely aesthetic. It is about institutional power — specifically, about whether the people who run the festival believe, at the level of institutional reflex rather than stated policy, that Afrikaans belongs equally and completely to all the communities who speak it. Stated policy and institutional reflex are different things. The gap between them is where most of the festival's unfinished business lives.

What does the KKNK owe Afrikaans? It owes it honesty about where the language comes from. Afrikaans did not emerge from the Boer republics or the Great Trek. It emerged from the Cape — from the contact zone between Dutch settlers, Malay and Indonesian enslaved people, Khoi communities, and the various migrant populations the VOC brought to the Cape between 1652 and the early nineteenth century. The word means, simply, African. The language is African in a way that its nationalist historiography went to extraordinary lengths to deny.

Honouring that etymology means programming the full spectrum of creative work produced in the language — recognising that the Islamic literary tradition written in Afrikaans in Arabic script, and the moppies and ghoemaliedjies of the Cape Malay musical tradition, are part of the same inheritance as the novels of Etienne le Roux or the poetry of N.P. van Wyk Louw. A festival serious about the language must hold all of this, without hierarchy. The main event is the full language.

It also means engaging with what the language was made to do. Jonker demonstrated that you could mourn, in Afrikaans, the children killed by the state whose language Afrikaans partly was. Breyten Breytenbach, writing from Parisian exile before his imprisonment, produced work that constituted the most potent argument the language could make against its own political capture. He lost eleven years of his life to a South African prison after he returned. The case he made — that Afrikaans was too valuable, too alive, too genuinely African to belong to the ideology that had seized it — was the right case. The KKNK exists, in some sense, because that case was made and partially won.

The festival at thirty-one is a different institution from the festival at five, and the difference is not merely cosmetic. But it is also not yet the institution the full community of Afrikaans speakers might reasonably expect. The studio productions that do not make the main stage, the literary programme that is too poorly attended, the commissions that arrive too late to performers who have been making work for decades without institutional support — these are the measure of a gap that the festival acknowledges, incompletely, in its programming intentions and has not yet closed in its institutional culture.

Cultural institutions do not transform through declarations. They transform through accumulation — of commissions, of programming choices, of whose name appears on the poster for the main stage, of whose work is acquired for the literary programme and whose is passed over. That accumulation is the only reliable measure of where the institution actually stands, as distinct from where it says it intends to go. The Klein Karoo will answer the question, production by production, over the next eight days.

CLOSING REFLECTION

Adam Small wrote Afrikaans from the position of someone the apartheid state had designated an inferior speaker of the language it had claimed. He did not accept the designation. Neither did Jonker. Neither did Breytenbach. The language survived its capture partly because those people refused to surrender it, and partly because the communities from whom it had been taken continued to speak it in their kitchens and churches and fishing boats, in registers the apartheid academy declined to recognise as legitimate.

The KKNK opens Saturday in their shadow, in a town in the heart of a country that has been trying, for thirty years, to inherit its own contradictions with more honesty than its founders managed. That work is slow and visible and worth watching closely. It proceeds on stage, in the Karoo, eight days a year.

One edition. Every Thursday. Thank you for reading.